Reading List: Chinese Economic History

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I. The Great Divergence & Historical National Accounting

I. The Great Divergence & National Accounting

1. Broadberry, S., Guan, H. & Li, D.D. (2018). "China, Europe, and the Great Divergence: A Study in Historical National Accounting, 980–1850." *JEH*, 78(4), 983–1048.
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2. Broadberry, S., Guan, H. & Li, D.D. (2021). "China, Europe, and the Great Divergence: A Restatement." *JEH*, 81(4), 1270–1282.
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3. Brandt, L., Ma, D. & Rawski, T.G. (2014). "From Divergence to Convergence: Reevaluating the History behind China's Economic Boom." *JEL*, 52(1), 45–123.
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I. The Great Divergence (cont.)

4. Li, B. & van Zanden, J.L. (2012). "Before the Great Divergence? Comparing the Yangzi Delta and the Netherlands at the Beginning of the Nineteenth Century." *JEH*, 72(4), 956–989.
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5. Xu, Y. & Shi, Z. (2019). "Chinese National Income, ca. 1661–1933." *AEHR*, 59(2), 196–229.
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6. Rawski, T.G. (2025). "Weak Data Nullify Bold Claims about Economic Trends in Qing China." *AEHR*, 65(2), 273–299.
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II. Market Integration & Trade

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1. Shiue, C.H. & Keller, W. (2007). "Markets in China and Europe on the Eve of the Industrial Revolution." *AER*, 97(4), 1189–1216.
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2. Shiue, C.H. (2002). "Transport Costs and the Geography of Arbitrage in Eighteenth-Century China." *AER*, 92(5), 1406–1419.
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3. Shiue, C.H. & Keller, W. (2007). "The Origins of Spatial Interaction: Evidence from Chinese Rice Markets, 1742–1795." *Journal of Econometrics*, 140(1), 304–332.
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II. Market Integration & Trade (cont.)

4. Keller, W., Shiue, C.H. & Santiago, J.A. (2017). "China's Domestic Trade During the Treaty Port Era." *EEH*, 63, 26–43.
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5. Mitchener, K.J. & Yan, S. (2014). "Globalization, Trade, and Wages: What Does History Tell Us About China?" *International Economic Review*, 55(1), 131–168.
   Link
6. Kung, J.K. & Ma, C. (2014). "Autarky and the Rise and Fall of Piracy in Ming China." *JEH*, 74(2), 509–534.
   Link
7. Keller, W., Li, B. & Shiue, C.H. (2013). "Shanghai's Trade, China's Growth: Continuity, Recovery, and Change since the Opium Wars." *IMF Economic Review*, 61(2), 336–378.
   Link

III. Political Fragmentation & State Formation

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1. Fernández-Villaverde, J., Koyama, M., Lin, Y. & Sng, T.-H. (2023). "The Fractured-Land Hypothesis." *QJE*, 138(2), 1173–1231.
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2. Ko, C.Y., Koyama, M. & Sng, T.-H. (2018). "Unified China and Divided Europe." *International Economic Review*, 59(1), 285–327.
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3. Sng, T.-H. & Moriguchi, C. (2014). "Asia's Little Divergence: State Capacity in China and Japan before 1850." *Journal of Economic Growth*, 19(4), 439–470.
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III. Political Fragmentation (cont.)

4. Koyama, M., Moriguchi, C. & Sng, T.-H. (2018). "Geopolitics and Asia's Little Divergence: State Building in China and Japan after 1850." *JEBO*, 155, 178–204.
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5. Sng, T.-H. (2014). "Size and Dynastic Decline: The Principal-Agent Problem in Late Imperial China, 1700–1850." *EEH*, 54, 107–127.
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6. Ma, D. & Rubin, J. (2019). "The Paradox of Power: Principal-Agent Problems and Administrative Capacity in Imperial China." *JCE*, 47(2), 277–294.
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7. Chen, J. (2024). "State Formation and Bureaucratization: Evidence from Pre-Imperial China." *JEH*, 84(3), 690–726.
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IV. Institutions: Keju & Elite Recruitment

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1. Bai, Y. & Jia, R. (2016). "Elite Recruitment and Political Stability: The Impact of the Abolition of China's Civil Service Exam." *Econometrica*, 84(2), 677–733.
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2. Chen, T., Kung, J.K. & Ma, C. (2020). "Long Live Keju! The Persistent Effects of China's Civil Examination System." *EJ*, 130(631), 2030–2064.
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3. Shiue, C.H. (2025). "Social Mobility in the Long Run: An Analysis of Tongcheng, China, 1300 to 1900." *JEH*, 85(1).
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IV. Institutions: Keju & Elite Recruitment (cont.)

4. Zhao, Y. & Xiong, H. (2023). "Sectarian Competition and the Market Provision of Human Capital." *JEH*, 83(1), 1–44.
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5. Chen, J., Wang, E.H. & Zhang, X. (2025). "From Powerholders to Stakeholders: State-Building with Elite Compensation in Early Medieval China." *AJPS*, 69, 607–623.
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6. Wang, E.H. & Yang, C.Z. (2023). "The Economic Consequences of Political Hierarchy: Evidence from Regime Changes in China, 1000–2000 CE." *REStat*, 105(3), 626–647.
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V. State Capacity & Fiscal History

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1. Shiue, C.H. (2004). "Local Granaries and Central Government Disaster Relief: Moral Hazard and Intergovernmental Finance in 18th–19th Century China." *JEH*, 64(1), 100–125.
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2. Hao, Y. & Liu, K.Z. (2020). "Taxation, Fiscal Capacity, and Credible Commitment in 18th-Century China." *EHR*, 73(4), 914–939.
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3. Hao, Y. (2025). "Telegraph and Capital Market Integration: Evidence from Late Imperial China." *EHR*, 78(1).
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V. State Capacity & Fiscal History (cont.)

4. Han, L. & Kung, J.K. (2015). "Fiscal Incentives and Policy Choices of Local Governments: Evidence from China." *JDE*, 116, 89–104.
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5. Kung, J.K. & Ma, C. (2014). "Can Cultural Norms Reduce Conflicts? Confucianism and Peasant Rebellions in Qing China." *JDE*, 111, 132–149.
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6. Sun, C. & Li, H. (2023). "The Celestial Empire: Solar Eclipses, Political Legitimacy, and Economic Performance in Historical China." *Cliometrica*, 17, 527–562.
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7. Chen, S. & Xie, B. (2024). "The Abolition of People's Communes and Fertility Decline in Rural China." *JDE*, 168, 103238.
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VI. Monetary & Financial History

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1. Ma, D. (2025). "China Inside Out: Explaining Silver Flows in the Triangular Trade, c. 1820s–70s." *EHR*, 78(1).
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2. Keller, W., Shiue, C.H. & Wang, X. (2021). "Capital Markets in China and Britain, 1770–1860: Evidence from Grain Prices." *AEJ: Applied*, 13(3), 31–64.
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3. Keller, W., Shiue, C.H. & Wang, X. (2020). "Capital Markets and Grain Prices: Assessing the Storage Cost Approach." *Cliometrica*, 14(2), 367–396.
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VI. Monetary & Financial History (cont.)

4. Zhao, W. (2016). "American Silver Inflow and the Price Revolution in Qing China." *Cliometrica*, 10(2), 161–187.
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5. Jacks, D.S., Yan, S. & Zhao, L. (2017). "Silver Points, Silver Flows, and the Measure of Chinese Financial Integration." *Journal of International Economics*, 108, 377–386.
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6. Ma, D. & Zhao, L. "A Silver Transformation: Chinese Monetary Integration in Times of Political Disintegration, 1898–1933." *Working Paper*.
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VII. Knowledge, Culture & Science

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1. Michalopoulos, S. & Xue, M.M. (2021). "Folklore." *QJE*, 136(4), 1993–2046.
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2. Ma, C. (2021). "Knowledge Diffusion and Intellectual Change: When Chinese Literati Met European Jesuits." *JEH*, 81(4), 1052–1097.
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3. Ma, C. (2024). "Classicism and Modern Growth: The Shadow of the Sages." *JEH*, 84(2), 395–431.
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VII. Knowledge, Culture & Science (cont.)

4. Dong, B. & Cheng, B. (2025). "Neo-Confucianism and the Rise of Science and Technology in Medieval China." *EHR*, 78(1).
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5. Xue, M.M. & Koyama, M. "Autocratic Rule and Social Capital: Evidence from Imperial China." *Working Paper*.
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6. Ma, D. & Rubin, J. (2024). "Ideology and Economic Change: The Contrasting Paths to the Modern Economy in Late 19th Century China and Japan." *Journal of Government and Economics*, 15, 100122.
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VIII. Demography, Gender & Human Capital

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1. Qian, N. (2008). "Missing Women and the Price of Tea in China: The Effect of Sex-Specific Earnings on Sex Imbalance." *QJE*, 123(3), 1251–1285.
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2. Wei, S.-J. & Zhang, X. (2011). "The Competitive Saving Motive: Evidence from Rising Sex Ratios and Savings Rates in China." *JPE*, 119(3), 511–564.
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3. Chen, S. & Kung, J.K. (2016). "Of Maize and Men: The Effect of a New World Crop on Population and Economic Growth in China." *Journal of Economic Growth*, 21(1), 71–99.
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VIII. Demography, Gender & Human Capital (cont.)

4. Shiue, C.H. (2017). "Human Capital and Fertility in Chinese Clans Before Modern Growth." *Journal of Economic Growth*, 22(4), 351–396.
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5. Shiue, C.H. (2016). "A Culture of Kinship: Chinese Genealogies as a Source for Research in Demographic Economics." *Journal of Demographic Economics*, 82(4), 459–482.
   Link
6. Chen, S. & Lan, X. "There Will Be Killing: Collectivization and Death of Draft Animals." *AEJ: Applied Economics*.
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IX. Climate, Disaster & Social Conflict

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1. Jia, R. (2014). "Weather Shocks, Sweet Potatoes and Peasant Revolts in Historical China." *EJ*, 124(575), 92–118.
   Link
2. Bai, L. & Wu, L. (2023). "Political Conflict and Development Dynamics: Economic Legacies of the Cultural Revolution." *JEH*, 83(4), 981–1017.
   Link
3. Li, D. & Li, N. (2017). "Move in the Right Place at the Right Time: The Economic Consequence of Manchuria 1910–11 Plague on Migrants." *EEH*, 63, 91–106.
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IX. Climate, Disaster & Social Conflict (cont.)

4. Shiue, C.H. (2022). "Size and Structure of Disaster Relief when State Capacity is Limited: China's 1823 Flood." *AEHR*, 62(3), 310–337.
   Link
5. Cheremukhin, A., Golosov, M., Guriev, S. & Tsyvinski, A. (2024). "The Political Development Cycle: The Right and the Left in PRC from 1953." *AER*, 114(4), 1107–1139.
   Link
6. Shiue, C.H. (2005). "The Political Economy of Famine Relief in China, 1740–1820." *Journal of Interdisciplinary History*, 36(1), 33–55.
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X. Living Standards & Wages

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1. Allen, R.C., Bassino, J.-P., Ma, D., Moll-Murata, C. & van Zanden, J.L. (2011). "Wages, Prices, and Living Standards in China, 1738–1925." *EHR*, 64(S1), 8–38.
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2. Liu, Z. (2024). "Wages, Labour Markets, and Living Standards in China, 1530–1840." *EEH*, 92.
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X. Living Standards & Wages (cont.)

4. Allen, R.C. (2009). "Agricultural Productivity and Rural Incomes in England and the Yangtze Delta, c. 1620–c. 1820." *EHR*, 62(3), 525–550.
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5. Deng, K.G. & O'Brien, P.K. (2016). "Establishing Statistical Foundations for the Great Divergence." *EHR*, 69(4), 1057–1082.
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XI. Long-run Persistence & Economic Development

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1. Jia, R. (2014). "The Legacies of Forced Freedom: China's Treaty Ports." *REStat*, 96(4), 596–608.
   Link
2. Song, Z., Storesletten, K. & Zilibotti, F. (2011). "Growing Like China." *AER*, 101(1), 196–233.
   Link
3. Zhao, Y. & Ma, N. (2025). "Catholicism in Early 20th Century China: A Re-examination." *EEH*, 98.
   Link

XI. Long-run Persistence (cont.)

4. Alesina, A., Seror, M., Yang, D.Y., You, Y. & Zeng, W. "Persistence through Revolutions." *NBER Working Paper* No. 27053.
   Link
5. Xue, M.M. "High-Value Work and the Rise of Women: The Cotton Revolution and Gender Equality in China." *Working Paper*.
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6. Wang, E.H. & Yang, C.Z. (2025). *The Political Economy of China's Imperial Examination System*. Cambridge University Press.
   Link
7. Ma, Y. (2024). *Essays on China's Economic History of the Late Qing Empire*. PhD Dissertation, University of Groningen.
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Thank You

Questions & Discussion

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